

this planned escalation with the trappings of a decision-making process, including meetings of the National Security Council, consultations with senior members of Congress, and a televised address to the nation. The major worry concerned the response of the Soviet Union, North Vietnam's ally. Nixon was shortly due in Moscow for a summit conference and signature of agreements on the nuclear arms race. The fear was that the Russians might cancel the summit and boost their aid to North Vietnam. It was also conceivable that they might respond to the mining of Haiphong with force.

Although the USSR responded by sending submarines and a flotilla of warships into the South China Sea, they kept the date for the summit. It was fortunate for the Americans that Soviet agricultural production during that year had fallen far short of its needs and the USSR needed to secure grain supplies from the United States.



Attack on Haiphong

US jets bomb warehouses and shipping areas in Haiphong on May 17, 1972. The mining of Haiphong occurred alongside the Linebacker I bombing campaign.

Mines in place

Initial preparations for Pocket Money were advancing in high gear by April 20 and the tactical plans were complete by April 23. Only one shipping channel led into Haiphong. It could be plugged with just a few strings of mines (in total, 36 were used). Mineman Second Class Robert D. Gill Jr. was sent from his duty post in Charleston, South Carolina, to the USS *Coral Sea* in the Gulf of Tonkin to prepare the mines.

On May 8, the operation was launched. Six LTV A-7 Corsair aircraft and three Grumman A-6A Intruders dropped the mines at the entrance to the harbor. Although the North Vietnamese retaliated, no planes were lost. The mines were programmed to activate at 6 p.m. local time on May 11. A number of visiting merchant vessels given warning of this deadline left port. Others, still unloading, remained, to be penned in until the end of 1972.